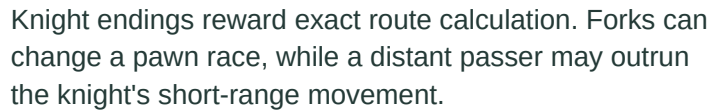


Knight-ending routes

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Map the knight's checking moves and its route to the critical blockade square. Count moves rather than judging distance by appearance.

The defending king is on d4. Geometrically undefended: knight on c6. Check for tactical protection.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

54...Nxc6+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. The move also takes the knight on c6. Recorded reply: 55.Kxd5.

At the end, nominal material is White 4 / Black 6 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

Using $P=1$, $N/B=3$, $R=5$, $Q=9$, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

A knight changes color with every move and may need a detour. Check the route square by square before trusting a race estimate.